

CARIBBEAN



HUNDREDS OF ISLANDS lie in the Caribbean Sea, east of the USA and Central America, and stretching west into the Atlantic Ocean. These Caribbean islands, also known as the West

Indies, take their name from the Caribs, the original inhabitants of the region, until the Spanish arrived in 1492. Most islanders today are descendents of African slaves brought to work in plantations between the 16th and 19th centuries. The islands have a tropical climate, turquoise waters, and fine beaches, and have developed a booming tourist industry. However, many people are poor and live by farming.

Physical features

Long, sandy beaches, tropical seas, and fine natural harbours have earned the Caribbean islands a reputation for beauty. Most of the islands are forested and mountainous. Some are volcanic in origin, others are founded on coral reefs. Hurricanes, earthquakes, and active volcanoes shake parts of the region from time to time.



Coral islands

The warm, tropical seas of the Caribbean provide ideal conditions for corals. Some of the Caribbean's volcanic islands, such as Barbados and the Cayman Islands, are fringed with coral reefs, which protect them against the lashing waves. The 700 islands and 2,300 islets of the Bahamas are entirely built up of coral, which can be viewed from the bridge that links Nassau with Paradise Island.



Volcanic islands

Many Caribbean islands are made of volcanic rocks that emerged from the ocean millions of years ago. Some, such as the St Lucian Gros Piton, 798 m (2,619 ft), and the Petit Piton, 750 m (2,461 ft), are the remains of ancient volcanoes that rise up from the sea on the west coast, near the town of Soufrière. One or two are still active, such as La Soufrière, at 1,219 m (4,000 ft) on St Vincent.



Hurricanes

Powerful tropical storms called hurricanes sweep the Caribbean between May and October every year, often causing great damage and economic hardship. They begin as thunderstorms that are whipped up by high winds and warm waters to form destructive stormclouds, swirling around a single centre at up to 360 kmh (220 mph). The violent winds and torrential rain can last for 18 hours.

